

BURROW

Brand & Logo Design Context Handoff

Purpose: preserve the thinking behind Burrow's identity so future logo, mascot, illustration, website, icon, and campaign explorations start from the same strategic foundation.



Current visual direction shown above is a reference point, not an immutable final asset.

1. Brand Philosophy

Burrow is a local-first, cloud-optional data ownership and recovery layer. It continuously copies critical business data into storage the customer controls, verifies that the copy is recoverable, and provides a unified interface for search, restore, and portability.

The logo therefore should not merely illustrate a rabbit, a cave, or a backup box. It should make the underlying promise feel intuitive: important things have a safe place to live, remain yours, and can be brought back when needed.

Core emotional territory

- Safe without feeling paranoid.
- Reliable without looking corporate or sterile.
- Playful without becoming childish.
- Technical without looking like infrastructure tooling.
- Ownable without looking proprietary or locked-in.
- Calm rather than fear-driven backup/security branding.

The name Burrow gives us a powerful metaphor: a private, protected place where something valuable is kept close and can still be accessed. The visual identity should exploit that metaphor while leaving room for the product to grow beyond email backup.

2. What the Logo Must Communicate

The strongest interpretation is protected independent copy, expressed through a friendly burrowing character or geometric creature. The character is not decoration. It is the human face of the product promise.

Primary meanings

- Burrow gives important data a safer home.
- The data is kept independently from the SaaS provider.
- The system is always there when recovery is needed.
- Burrow is quietly working in the background.
- The customer remains in control of where the copy lives.

Secondary meanings

- Curiosity: the creature naturally wants to inspect, dig, discover and understand.
- Persistence: digging implies patient, continuous work.
- Protection: the underground home implies shelter.
- Portability: the creature can appear anywhere, across local and cloud environments.
- Friendliness: the mascot makes an otherwise intimidating reliability product approachable.

The logo should avoid making a literal claim that Burrow is only an email archive. It must remain credible if the product eventually protects Drive, Microsoft 365, Slack, GitHub, databases, documents, and other SaaS data.

3. Character / Mascot Philosophy

A mascot is not a separate brand from the logo. It should be the logo's expandable personality layer.

The ideal character

- Small, compact silhouette with a recognizable head and body shape.
- A simple face with very few features, allowing expression through pose rather than facial detail.
- Short paws/hands that can interact with objects and UI concepts.
- A body that can plausibly emerge from a burrow, carry things, work, rest, celebrate or investigate.
- Friendly and curious rather than hyperactive or cartoonishly cute.
- No dependence on realistic animal anatomy.

The character should be capable of a complete expression system:

- Peek → discovery / onboarding
- Curious → search / inspection
- Digging → syncing / ingestion
- Carrying → moving data
- Working → background jobs
- Relaxing → healthy / nothing to do
- Celebrating → successful backup / recovery
- Concerned → something needs attention

This makes the mascot useful as product UI language, not just marketing art.

4. Visual Language

The visual direction should feel like a 2D illustrated system made from simple planes and shapes. Think dimensionality through shape overlap, not through 3D rendering.

Shape rules

- Prefer flat polygons and clean organic curves.
- Use a small number of planes to imply form.
- Avoid gradients as the primary way of creating depth.
- Avoid realistic fur, texture, photographic detail or complex line art.
- Use negative space deliberately.
- Allow slight asymmetry so the identity feels alive.

The geometric treatment is important because it lets the same character exist at multiple levels: tiny app icon, clean logo mark, illustrated website mascot, onboarding animation, and campaign artwork.

Current reference palette

Role	Reference	Use
Deep brown	#2E1F1A	Primary wordmark / dark surfaces
Earth brown	#8B5E3C	Character body / secondary planes
Warm sand	#D9B895	Character face / highlights
Soft cream	#F7EFE7	Background / negative space
Muted green	#6BA67A	Nature / success / secondary accent

5. Typography Direction

Typography should counterbalance the softness of the mascot. If the character is warm and playful, the wordmark needs enough structural confidence to make Burrow feel like real infrastructure.

Direction

- Modern geometric or humanist sans-serif.
- Strong lowercase treatment is preferred for approachability.
- Avoid overly futuristic typefaces.
- Avoid playful handwritten typography for the core wordmark.
- Use expressive handwritten or sketch-like typography only as a secondary campaign/mascot layer.

The current reference uses a heavy rounded wordmark with a friendly lowercase feel. Preserve the idea of confident + approachable, even if the exact typeface changes.

The wordmark should be recognizable without the mascot. The mascot should also be recognizable without the wordmark. They must work as a system, not as one inseparable illustration.

6. Decisions, Rejections & Why

Direction	Assessment	Decision
Literal rabbit / rodent mascot	Strong name recognition and warmth, but can become generic and lose character.	Keep animal concept, refine character.
Tunnel / cave icon	Good shelter metaphor but too abstract and can look like storage/security software.	Storage/security software.
Shield / lock	Immediately says security, but shifts brand toward cybersecurity and fear.	Reject.
Database / server icon	Technically descriptive but cold and limits category perception.	Reject.
Pure geometric B	Clean and scalable, but loses the memorable human story.	Use Burrow's hidden structural inspiration.
Cute cartoon animal	Approachable but risks looking like a consumer game or kids' product.	Reject due to exaggerated cuteness.
Flat polygonal animal	Balances playfulness, technical clarity, scalability and mascot potential.	Preferred direction.

The current chosen direction was evaluated across founder, designer, engineer, SMB customer, technical buyer, investor, brand distinctiveness, long-term fit and small-size legibility. The target is $\geq 9.7/10$, not because numerical scoring is objective, but because forcing multiple perspectives helps expose one-dimensional branding decisions.

7. Product → Visual Metaphor Mapping

Product idea	Visual expression
Continuous sync	Digging / active movement
Protected storage	Burrow / underground home
Independent copy	Nested or separated object / safe chamber
Verification	Curious inspection / checking
Recovery	Emerging from the burrow / retrieving something
Customer-owned storage	A home that belongs to the character, not the cloud
Healthy system	Relaxed / sleeping mascot
Attention needed	Subtle concerned expression, not alarmist red
Successful restore	Celebration / recovered object
Search	Curious / looking around
Portability	Mascot carrying a box/object

8. Reusable Image-Generation Context

This section is intentionally written so it can be pasted into a future image-generation conversation before asking for a new logo, mascot, icon or illustration.

Master context

Brand: Burrow

Product: local-first, cloud-optional SaaS data ownership and recovery layer. Burrow continuously copies critical business data into storage the customer controls, verifies recoverability, and provides search, restore and portability.

Brand metaphor: a safe burrow where valuable things are kept, protected and available when needed.

Personality: curious, reliable, calm, playful, quietly competent, always there.

Visual style: flat 2D illustration built from clean polygons and simple organic shapes. Dimensionality comes from layered planes and overlap, not photorealism or glossy 3D effects.

Character: compact friendly burrowing animal, loosely inspired by a small rodent/marmot-like creature, with a simple face, expressive paws and a silhouette that works as a logo. It should feel like infrastructure with a personality, not a children's cartoon.

Core idea: protected independent copy. The character should visually suggest that important data has a safe home and can be recovered.

Must support: standalone logo mark, wordmark, favicon/app icon, and a larger mascot system with multiple poses and expressions.

Avoid: shields, locks, database/server icons, generic cloud icons, crypto aesthetics, excessive gradients, photorealistic animals, childish cartoon styling, overly complex line art, generic tech mascots.

Prompting principle

Do not ask the generator to simply “make a Burrow logo.” Give it the brand meaning + visual constraints + intended future mascot system. Otherwise generators tend to optimize for the literal dictionary meaning of the name and produce a generic rabbit/cave icon.

9. Logo & Mascot System Rules

Primary mark

- Must be identifiable in silhouette alone.
- Should work in monochrome.
- Should not depend on tiny facial details.
- Should remain legible at favicon size.
- Should not require the full illustrated environment.

Mascot expansion

- Keep the same head/body proportions across poses.
- Keep the same eye and facial language.
- Use props to communicate product states instead of redesigning the character.
- Allow environmental scenes such as soil, plants, boxes, files, screens and storage objects.
- Use expressions sparingly. The character should remain calm and understated.

Motion / future animation

- Small digging motion for syncing.
- Peek-out motion for notifications.
- Gentle carrying motion for transfer.
- Dust particles or small soil movement can signal activity.
- Celebration should be subtle rather than explosive.

10. Future Review Checklist

Every future visual exploration should be judged against these questions before approval.

- Does this communicate Burrow rather than generic backup software?
- Does it feel playful without becoming childish?
- Can the mark become a mascot naturally?
- Does it still work if Burrow protects many kinds of SaaS data?
- Does it communicate safety without fear or cybersecurity clichés?
- Is the silhouette recognizable at small sizes?
- Does the design work in monochrome?
- Are the shapes simple enough to reproduce consistently?
- Could the character have at least 8 useful product-related poses?
- Would the design look credible on a technical product's website?
- Does it feel distinctive enough to build a brand around?
- Is there any decorative detail that does not serve meaning?

Approval threshold

Target $\geq 9.7/10$. If a concept scores highly on aesthetics but poorly on product meaning, reject it. If it communicates the product perfectly but looks generic, iterate it. The goal is the intersection of meaning $\times$ distinctiveness $\times$ scalability $\times$ personality.

11. Current State & Next Exploration

Current preferred direction: flat polygonal burrowing creature with a strong compact silhouette, warm earth palette, confident lowercase wordmark, and a mascot system built from poses and props.

The current reference board demonstrates:

- Full and compact logo lockups.
- Monochrome treatment.
- App-icon direction.
- Multiple mascot poses.
- Earth/cream/green palette.
- Friendly, confident typography.
- Simple environmental scenes.

What should improve next

- Make the creature's silhouette more distinctive and ownable.
- Reduce any unnecessary detail that disappears at small sizes.
- Ensure the logo mark works independently from the wordmark.
- Develop a stronger visual relationship between the animal and the concept of a protected copy.
- Create a consistent geometry system so future poses look like the same character.
- Explore a slightly more playful personality while preserving technical credibility.

Do not restart from zero unless a new direction demonstrably beats the current one on product meaning, scalability and mascot potential.

12. Short Context Block

For quick future sessions, use this compressed version when the full document is unnecessary:

BURROW BRAND CONTEXT: Burrow is a local-first, cloud-optional SaaS data ownership and recovery product. It continuously copies important business data into storage the customer controls, verifies that the copy is recoverable, and makes search/restore/portability easy. The brand metaphor is a safe burrow: a quiet, dependable home for valuable things that remains independent from the SaaS provider. The identity should be playful, curious and warm, but still credible as infrastructure. Preferred visual direction is a flat 2D polygonal burrowing creature with a compact, highly recognizable silhouette. The creature must work as a logo and expand naturally into a mascot system with poses such as peeking, digging, carrying, working, relaxing, inspecting and celebrating. Use simple layered planes and organic geometric shapes, warm earth tones, cream backgrounds and restrained green accents. Avoid shields, locks, generic clouds, databases, crypto aesthetics, photorealism, glossy 3D and childish cartoon styling. The logo should communicate protected independent copy, not merely “animal” or “backup.” Every new exploration should be evaluated for product meaning, distinctiveness, scalability, mascot potential, technical credibility and small-size legibility. Target quality: $\geq 9.7/10$.

End of handoff document